



Making a return: Ishan Kishan, featuring for India C, smashed a 126-ball 111 on his comeback to red-ball cricket since making his Test debut last July. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

first match to join the Bangladesh Test series. Their departure provided an opportunity for seasoned First-Class players to catch the selectors' attention.

Abhimanyu Easwaran, still awaiting a consistent run in the Indian team, showcased his talent with two centuries — one of which was an unbeaten knock for India B against India C in the second round. However, despite scoring 309 runs, Easwaran was only the second-highest run-scorer, surpassed by Ricky Bhui, a veteran of domestic cricket. Bhui, representing India D, amassed 359 runs in six innings, including two centuries.

Even now, the best these players can hope for is a call-up for an 'A' tour to Australia later this year, as

overtaking Sarfaraz Khan, Devdutt Padikkal, and Sudharsan in the pecking order seems unlikely.

New names also rose to the occasion. One such player was Baroda's Shashwat Rawat, who was part of the victorious India A team. Rawat scored three fifty-plus innings in four outings, including a crucial 124 in the final round that helped India A tighten its grip on India C. This performance, which followed his 784-run tally in the Ranji Trophy last season, proved he could compete at the highest levels.

"This is the first time I've made it

to this stage. It validated my efforts in last season's Ranji Trophy, where I scored four hundreds in eight games, including a double century. I had a feeling I might be selected, so I was prepared," said Rawat.

His teammate, 20-year-old Aaqib Khan, who replaced Akash Deep for the last two games, impressed with his seam bowling, taking eight wickets in four innings. He particularly cherished dismissing India D's Sanju Samson, forcing him into a mistimed pull shot with extra pace and bounce.

"It's a big deal for me. I'm still a



The thrilling finale was a reminder that the Duleep Trophy still holds some relevance, especially ahead of the upcoming domestic season.